



AFC Newsletter

Michaelmas 2025



Dear esteemed reader,

welcome to the newly revived newsletter, Which over summer i have lovingly committed necromancy just so you all can enjoy the words and creativity of the AFC community (now with added gravedirt) My acts of sorcery forced me to actually do reading outside of term (sadly lectures don't cover resurrection) so you, reader, better enjoy this! I do hope that this publication does find you before Michaelmas sets in so you can enjoy it fully without too many looming deadlines!

Inside are some wonderful contributions from members who have been rewarded with my thanks, and I hope you enjoy reading their work! Prepare for the true account of the legendary battle between cows and archaeologists in turkey, and the challenges of putting on an opera in the ruins of a priory! There's also some very useful updates on society plans so you can plan your Michaelmas around the AFC like the dedicated followers I know you all are [we don't have any real timetables, so why not].

Thank you to everyone who contributed and thank you to anyone who is reading it! I'd love for this newsletter to be able to provide an outlet for anyone to share their interests and creativity and really build an archaeology community outside of the department. Also, I hope you are all exited for upcoming society events, and for the next newsletter which you should all be inspired to provide contributions for.

Signed you newsletter editor, necromancer, and AFC vice president, **Ellie**

welcome back!

Welcome back, old and new AFC members, are you ready for Michaelmas! [I don't think I am] Over summer the committee has been working to plan the terms events, including guest speakers and plenty of pub nights, as well as instituting membership fees and a new bank account, very exiting! Theirs also plans for a Michaelmas stash drop, which I'm sure will make a great Christmas gift for any member! Hopefully you've had a nice summer and are ready to read what other members have been up to. Don't forget the department party on October 17th, and good luck for the new year! I hope to see all of you at the events planned this year!



upcoming events!

- boardgame nights
- pub nights
- AFC crafternoons
- guest talks

check the calender for more details!

**New
committee member**
Congratulations to our
welfare officer, Alex!



shrimp enjoying the CAU over summer!



**and now, the hair-raising completely true
account of secretary Erin's summer
fieldwork!**



This summer I spent a highly memorable two weeks with the team excavating Aşıklı Höyük and Balıklı Höyük, two Neolithic settlement sites in Kapadokya in Turkey. My main memories of my time at the dig house are being bitten by mosquitoes as I stuffed my mouth with metric tonnes of fresh (and slightly less fresh) Turkish bread and tried not to suffocate on metric tonnes of second-hand cigarette smoke. I have since been suffering from debilitating withdrawal symptoms due to the complete and sudden removal of both substances from my life. I have, however, appreciated the return to a traditional shower set up, leaving behind the bucket-and-jug shower for good.

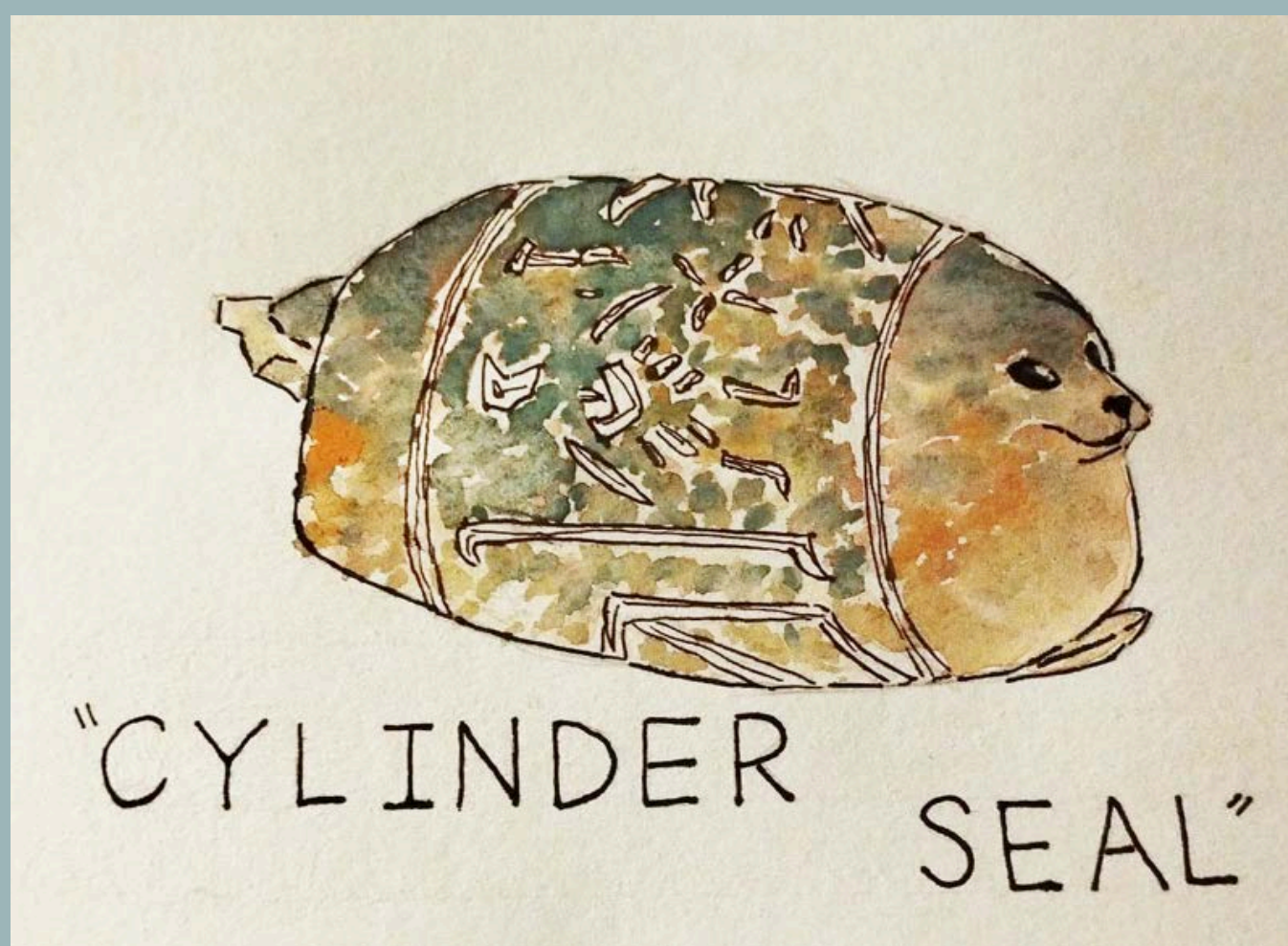
Despite the jarring 6:30 am start, the actual excavation work was a far cry from mattocking your way through three metres of clay until you hit the bottom of your medieval ditch (and the water table). I was handed a paintbrush (perfect for painting your mom's fence) and instructed to 'clean' the plaster floor. This largely consisted of aggressively brushing away very fine and very dry dust from the floor, only for it to blow directly into your eyes and mouth and also somehow exactly back onto the area of floor that you were trying to clean. Sometimes you also got hit by the dust that someone else was brushing away. One must imagine an archaeologist happy.



One such episode of frantic and ultimately futile brushing was interrupted when the chariots of fire music began playing. We all dramatically dropped our tools to watch in awed silence as one of the students ran in slow motion towards the open gate leading into the site. Three equally slow-motion cows were nonchalantly ambling towards it. They looked her—still too far away to secure the gate—in the eye and stepped through the gate. They immediately returned to a normal playback speed and began to jog towards the trenches, intent on trampling some Neolithic skeletons. Of course, this COULD NOT happen: only we, as entirely human archaeologists, could trample on the Neolithic archaeology. The only possible solution to this problem was to throw rocks at them until they accepted our dominance and ceded the territory to us. We were victorious and went back to trampling all over the Neolithic buildings. It will forever be known as the Balıklı Höyük Cow War of 2025.

After we immortalised our heroic victory by composing a 100,000-word epic poem, we came together to find some common ground, in spite of our cultural differences. It was not the academic joys of archaeology but, of course, the Shrek cinematic universe. We relaxed after a hard day of gruelling war and less gruelling brushing with homemade pizza and a Shrek marathon, cementing our comradeship forever. Are you a real Shrek fan if you haven't experienced the Turkish dub? Who needs Mike Myers when you have Okan Bayülgen?

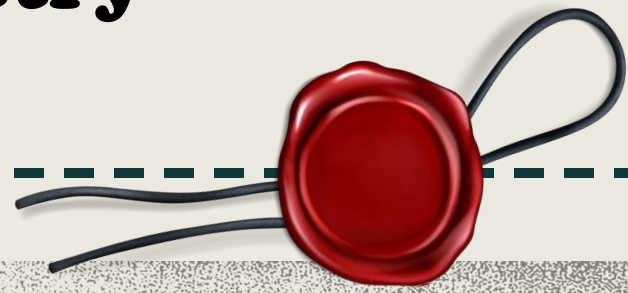
Overall, my time in Turkey was highly educational, helping me to grow as an archaeologist and as a person. I am deeply grateful to the dig team and the University of Cambridge for providing me with this excellent opportunity and I hope I will be able to return in the future.



Beautiful artwork by our glorious
publicity officer, Jane

up next, a review of the game Poetry for Neanderthals

by Hebe



I first came across this game in my supervisor's office, where it sat on a top shelf, watching me sweat under the pressure of a supo that was, coincidentally, about Neanderthals.

I bought and played the game much later, and while it has absolutely no bearing on the state of Neanderthal language-capabilities, it remains great fun, suitable for both (college) families and friends.

Premise of the game

'Poetry for Neanderthals' is card game a bit like 'Articulate!', where players try to get their teammate to say the word or phrase written on a card, without themselves saying those words.

The Neanderthal-twist is that the player holding the card (known as the Poet) cannot use words of more the 1 syllable. If the Poet does break a rule, they are whacked with the NO! Stick - an inflatable plastic club adorned with a frowning face - perhaps an early instance of Neanderthal art.

Altogether the roles are Poet, Guesser, Judge (wielder of the club) and the Timekeeper, who uses a sand timer to keep time and declares when turns are over. Rapid turns are what makes this game fun, as the quick pace creates a sense of urgency, making it harder to think of appropriate words, and leading to more mistakes, lost time and panic!

How it goes in practice

From my experience, players fall into one of two categories: those who are surprisingly good at being descriptive with only 1 syllable words, or those who immediately panic and are unable to think of any words, let alone relevant ones. Unfortunately, for the first few rounds, I fell into the second category as my mind froze over into its own hellish ice age and I was left tongue-tied, much to the amusement of my fellow players.

And yet, like Neanderthals (for the most part) the more you play under these conditions, the more you get used to it and adapt. I would recommend all players start with a practice round to acclimatise and get over the initial panic of having to use your brain under time pressure. Fortunately, if you're dealing with a particularly busy week of supervisions and not really in the mood to use your brain, losing this game is just as much fun a winning (provided the Judge isn't too heavy-handed with the NO! Stick...)

Downsides

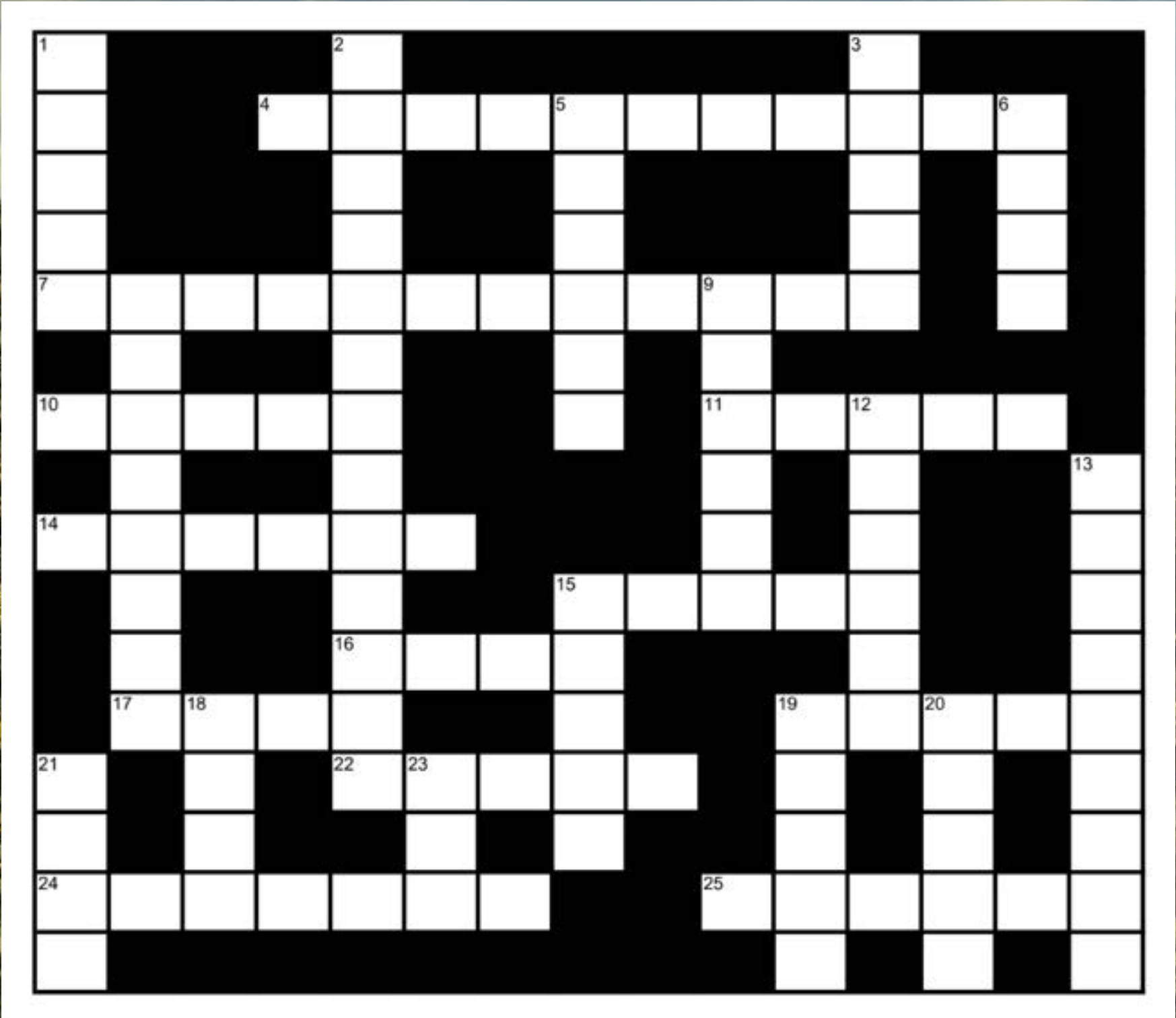
Overall, the game is very simple, and while that makes it easy to learn there is the potential for it to become a little repetitive. A solution to this could be found through switching to one of the themed expansion packs, which include pop culture and NSFW, which might be a good fix if players start to get bored by or overly familiar with the cards.

Furthermore, some of the cards feature American terms and phrases that can be difficult to translate if players aren't familiar with them. This shouldn't be too much of a problem for most players, but I will say that trying to explain 'hackey sack' to my parents was not an enjoyable experience.

Another minor issue was keeping track of player's turns using the sand timer. In several instances, play ran over because the Timekeeper got so distracted by game play that they forgot about timekeeping all together (watching a panicking, tongue-tied Poet is, I think, one of the funniest things I have ever seen and very difficult to stop watching). A quick fix could be to instead set a timer with an audible alarm, or for the Judge to whack the Timekeeper every so often to remind them of their task.

My rating: 4.5/5 

Overall, 'Poetry for Neanderthals' is an elegantly simple yet incredibly fun card game, and I would hugely recommend giving it a go. If you're not willing to buy it yourself there's no need to panic, as you are sure to see me running around Cambridge with an inflatable club, trying to convince you all to play another round.



Archaeology Crossword

- Across

 - 4) Greatest (bath) of all time (11)
 - 7) Layers (12)
 - 10) Average British dig (5)
 - 11) Erase the trees (5)
 - 14) Of or relating to the stars (6)
 - 15) Country with pyramids (5)
 - 16) Henge Shape (4)
 - 17) Tropical starchy tuberous root (4)
 - 19) Mountain Range (5)
 - 22) Scuba user (5)
 - 24) DNA/RNA base (7)
 - 25) We'll be lucky if we get one (6)
- Down

 - 1) Egyptian symbols of life (5)
 - 2) The first and only female Disney Professor (7,6)
 - 3) _____ Cunliffe (5)
 - 5) Salt used for mummification in Egypt (6)
 - 6) Ice Man (4)
 - 8) Cut across something (8)
 - 9) Political unit (6)
 - 12) Bone surrounding the pulp cavity of a tooth (6)
 - 13) Alice Roberts Book (8)
 - 15) Bird, as a heiroglyph meaning 'tremble' (5)
 - 18) Woodworking tool (4)
 - 19) City founded by Sargon the Great (5)
 - 20) 'Il n'y a pas des histoires sans ____' (4)
 - 21) Blue dyestuff (4)
 - 23) Charged particle (3)

An Archaeology Crossword? ...
How sophisticated

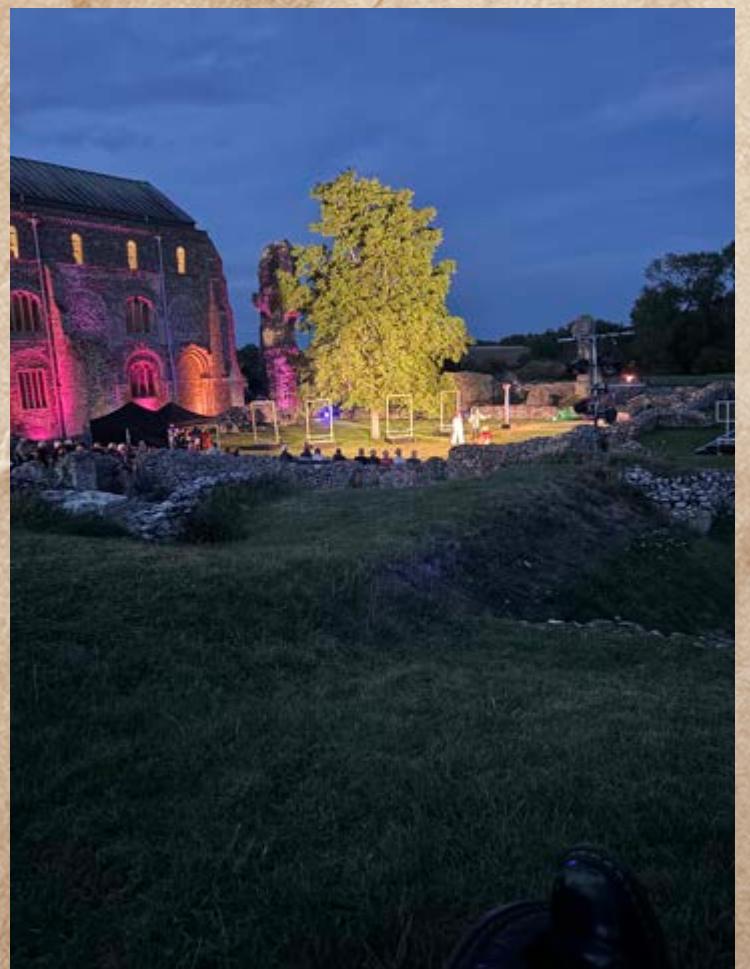
Created by Hannah, our treasurer

The trials and tribulations of putting on an opera, In the ruins of a priory

My account of Ruddigore at Binham Priory

When I, scrolling camdram at midnight, saw that the Gilbert and Sullivan society were planning to perform the opera Ruddigore in the ruins of a Norfolk priory, my interest was captured, and I signed on to join the 60+ person company as a costume assistant. What followed was a series of challenges that the organisers, non-archaeologists, evidently did not foresee, but that I was not shocked by. Partaking in this project as an archaeologist was a unique experience, as my concern for the monuments safety, and interest in the site's history was not commonly shared, with most focus being on the show and the present, but I naturally could not help but return to the past.

Binham Prior, located on the north Norfolk coast and construction was completed in the 13th century [practically modern compared to the depths of prehistory] before falling to ruin after some king dissolved it, wonder who that was? Currently it consists of the still standing nave and numerous walls in various stages of decay. It was a beautiful location, with the lighting team painting the ruins in colourful light, and the themes of the opera matching the haunting location. Ruddigore poses questions of morality to a main character literally haunted by his ancestors, with the ruined grandeur of the priory helping create this atmosphere. And whilst I could detail an analysis of the setting and staging, this is about archaeology, so let us return to that.



Turns out the typical problem of past archaeologists not recording their excavations would hit this production, something that I should really have anticipated, given how irritatingly frequently it happens in archaeological work. Turns out that during excavations in the 1930s details of the priory layout had been discovered, including some flooring, which of course was re-covered and its location promptly forgotten. Thus, we were banned from using pegs in our construction of deck and truss needed to make the not fit for purpose ruins into something usable. The tents used to house the band had to be secured with weights, which when faced with the open coastal location and 50mph wind did not want to stay on the ground. During the final performance most of the crew stood in the band tent, and struggled against the gale to hold it down. Whilst the band tent survived the run, the lighting tent was an unfortunate rehearsal casualty, being lost to wind before performances begun, with a novel solution being thought up to instead put the lighting desk in a car boot.

The ruined walls, which naturally we were prohibited to touch posed a bit of a hazard, especially when deconstructing deck in the dark of 1am. It was decided that the get-out, the theatre term for deconstructing anything built for your show, would take place after the final evening performance, so begun at 10:30 pm, and given that the lights were first to go much of it took place in the dark, and the wind, and the rain. In the dark the ruins, especially when burdened by the weight of whatever you were carrying thus transformed from archaeological remains to trip hazards, especially to me, as I trip up on my own two feet. My fear of tripping and damaging any archaeology, something that I'm not sure the other company members were concerned by was replaced by a fear of tripping. I have never excavated in the rain, so when at 2am it began pouring I was a little inexperienced. Equipment quickly became slippery, the walls more hazardous, and the mood darker and desperate. By 4am I was soaked through and incredibly cold, and retreated to the warmth of the standing church, which being a church was not very warm. I am unsure if the conditions we faced are more comparable to a wet excavation or trench warfare, but I am at least now prepared.

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If I were the ghost of a monk watching our antics I'm not sure how I would feel. Being written in the 1880s the opera contained a lack of elements I would find religiously blasphemous, however I'm not sure our treatment of the interior of the church, with the font becoming shelving to serve dinner from was perhaps not the most religiously respectful, but as an atheist I'm unqualified in the topic. However this production did pose an interesting perspective of the use of archaeological sites and the ethics of using the space for something it clearly was not intended for. Binham priory is a public space, so open to all and not protected by the same sanctity that archaeologists treat sights and materials with. In archaeology materials are understood from the perspective of their makers and users, with efforts to understand their purpose and role in society, with this act of interpretation becoming an act of respect. In other words, using a priory to perform theatre is not an archaeologists practice of preserving and respecting past intentions. Whilst I am not compelled to explore this topic from an academic perspective in this newsletter, after all term has not started yet, it remains an interesting question to ponder. Ruddigore at binham priory was a learning experience, both in the challenges of staging theatre, but also in heritage and the use of archaeological remains, their conservation, and how we respect their purpose.

If you managed to make it to the end of my drivel, congratulations, I'm terrible at not writing more words than necessary, something that at 1am when I have to cut 200 words from my essays becomes very painful



anecdotes straight from the SLR

The unorganised
bio practical of A2
(iykyk) [ask a
second year, it'll be
like recounting a
memory from the
war]

Simon Stoddart
commenting on how
terribly strange it is
that there was no
combination of fish and
milk found at Must
Farm, because fish
microwaved in a bowl
of milk is his "favourite
meal"

Being told to 'engage
intimately with the slag'
in a practical

counting the number
of slides gone
through in an A3
lecture

Mr beast being used
as a source in a
lecture, you just had
to be there

Time for Tea?



Oh crumbs!! Biscuit tins, thoughts and theories

Just before the start of term I was walking through the V&A with a couple of my friends. One of them happens to be the former editor of this newsletter actually, and it was his first visit to the Victoria and Albert Museum. I'd been countless times but as anyone who's ever tried to see the entire museum in a couple of hours will know, there's a lifetime's worth of exploration in that place.

Walking through the section devoted to metalwork, I remember being struck by the mundanity of it all. Here was a palace of art, science and culture with huge collections of material culture from six continents across the globe, the majority of which not on display, dedicating half a floor to metal railings and British biscuit tins. I'd love to say that that got me thinking deeply right then and there about the significance of those things, but frankly, I only really started thinking about them when I needed a funky example for this newsletter. Nevertheless, I do now believe that as users and theorists on material culture, archaeologists can learn a lot from the biscuit tin.

When does a biscuit tin stop being a biscuit tin? Most of us have biscuit tins in our houses which we use to store things other than biscuits. Famously for instance, the AFC's cash reserves are kept in a biscuit tin. Perhaps the biscuit tin is more famous for its reuse than its initial purpose, in a way few objects are. It certainly spends most of its time in use not being a biscuit tin than being one. Some biscuit tins in the V&A collection even seem to acknowledge this fact by imitating other materials, especially baskets, in a skeuomorphic way



A fancy biscuit tin obviously means that you pay more for your biscuits. Or, more precisely, you pay more for the tin with the biscuits in. To what extent therefore are the biscuits inside just an excuse to buy the tin? Is the reason that biscuit tins are seemingly more popular than other types just because they have biscuits (a sweet treat) inside? Why have jars, or lunchboxes or clamshell containers never become as decorated nor as quintessential as the biscuit tin? These are the questions I have never asked before about my favourite biscuit tin. I won't pretend to have anywhere near all the answers but looking at some older tins can reveal some clues.

Many of the V&A's biscuit tins, the moveable globe especially for instance, were clearly made with design in mind first, and biscuits only as an afterthought. Their designation as biscuit tins perhaps makes them more marketable (both instant and sustained gratification), or gives these types of designs a more accessible feel for consumers. In a way they exemplify Lefebvre's Critique of Everyday Life in which he argues that the commercialization of boredom and of the mundanity of everyday existence is how capitalism survives and grows. The constantly varying designs of the tins are a good indicator of middle-class fashions over time. I especially like the Egyptian vases as biscuit tins made in 1924, just two years after the discovery of Tutankhamun's tomb.

Looking at the changes in biscuit tins over time is interesting because their changes are all caused by external factors for instance changing fashions, or the availability of metal during the wars. In a way, I find it comforting to think that the biscuits hidden away inside the tins, or most probably already eaten by the people who owned them, stayed more or less unchanged throughout large swathes of their history. I think there's something quite poetic in that the consumable, quickly eaten biscuits have stayed true to their original selves whilst the designs and shapes of their long-lasting containers have changed with each fleeting fashion. But then again, maybe I've just been thinking about biscuit tins for too long.

Evan Grandidge de Paz



Treasurer Updates

Hello everyone! So far it has been an absolute pleasure being the AFC treasurer! Luke, Simon, and I have been working hard to get our bank account sorted, which means we will soon have the financial backing to start planning our rise to the top (imagine evil laughter). On a serious note, this will really increase the scope of what the AFC can do, so watch this space for updates! Also, please pay your membership fees and collect one of our wonderful membership cards - you know you want to!!

AFC business aside, I have had lots of archaeology-related shenanigans this summer that I will attempt to write about in an amusing way. For part of my fieldwork, I spent a brilliant two weeks in August building an experimental Roman glassworking furnace as part of a PhD project. As you can tell from the state of my trousers, it was messy work involving a lot of very wet clay. I became very intimately acquainted with the furnace, often having both arms inside it, talking gently to it and persuading it not to collapse. Most of the time, however, was spent manufacturing bricks using clay and chopped hay. This was mostly good fun, but in the more tedious moments it did have me questioning some of my life choices. Luckily, I soon became the resident public engager of the group and had great fun flagging down slightly awkward-looking members of the public and asking them 'would you like to hear about Roman glass?' in a way that made it clear 'no' was not an acceptable answer. This was an excellent exercise in getting rid of a lot of social anxiety, and also demonstrated that the principle transferable skill of a Cambridge Archaeology degree is being able to convincingly talk about something you actually know only 3 things about.

These are the 3 things I told every willing (and non-willing) passer by:

Glass was only made in the Eastern part of the empire, so glassworking outside of this region was only recycling, not manufacturing. This is because the sand elsewhere was not pure enough

Part of the reason we don't find much Roman glass archaeologically is because it was kept to be sold for recycling and rarely thrown away

Later Roman window panes are made with blown glass, but earlier ones (and the ones that are the subject of the PhD project) are moulded in some way, but we don't really understand how, so that is what the project aims to find out

This project was based at Butser Ancient Farm, which is a brilliant site well worth a visit if you're in the area. They have reconstructed buildings from the Neolithic through to the Saxon periods, complete with furnishings and even functional looms! The staff really are the icing on the cake as well, everyone is so passionate about their area of interest and there are many interesting conversations to be had. I think my favourite was talking about how it feels to ride a motorbike in full replica Roman armour. The gift shop is also amazing and stocks a good selection of archaeology-related books (I won't reveal what percentage of my fieldwork budget was spent here).

Through this I was lucky enough to meet the curator of Fishbourne Roman Palace, who gave me and our wonderful AFC secretary Jane a guided tour of the site and its archives. We had a great time playing 'spot the mistake in the mosaic' and finding out a few of the awkward mistakes in the museum displays. Unfortunately I can't share those, but hopefully that adds a layer of intrigue if you ever go and visit...

I have also been invited to gatecrash UCL's 'archaeotech' weekend, which has always been a point of jealousy for many of us Cambridge students, who sadly don't get to start our degrees with a weekend making cheese and bread Neolithic style. Unfortunately this is happening after the submission deadline, but I will be taking careful notes and sharing them with you all, so that nobody feels they are missing out anymore.

I hope everyone in the society has had a wonderful, archaeology-filled summer and I can't wait to serve out the rest of my term as your diligent, financially responsible treasurer!



The finished furnace!
Photo credit: Therese Kearns



I have never had more admiration for the inventor of the cement mixer than I had in this moment
Photo credit: Pippa Launchbury